



in Toronto, where Gukesh battled against a formidable field in the 2024 Candidates Tournament. Competing against chess heavyweights — like 2018 World championship challenger USA's Fabiano Caruana, World No. 3 USA's Hikaru Nakamura, the youngest-ever to 2800 Elo rating, Firouzja, two-time World championship challenger Russia's Ian Nepomniachtchi, and compatriots Praggnanandhaa and Vidit — Gukesh emerged victorious, earning the right to challenge Ding for the World championship.

The finale in Toronto was a tense four-way contest for the top spot. Gukesh led by half a point heading into the last round, where he faced Nakamura. Meanwhile, Caruana squared off against Nepomniachtchi, with all three chasing Gukesh, needing wins to catch him. In the 14th round, Gukesh held Nakamura to a draw, while Caruana squandered a winning position against Nepomniachtchi. This sealed Gukesh's historic victory, making him

the youngest-ever winner of the Candidates and only the second Indian after Anand to claim the prestigious title.

Gukesh's achievements didn't stop there. At the Budapest Chess Olympiad, he led India to its first-ever gold medal in the Open section, delivering a stunning 9/10 performance on Board 1. Gukesh's dominance was unparalleled, with eight wins and a tournament-best 3000+ performance rating. His back-to-back gold medals, mirroring his performance from 2022, leave little doubt about his ability to reign at the top.

A golden year

India's golden run in Budapest wasn't limited to the Open section. The Indian women's team, comprising Harika, Vaishali, Vantika Agrawal, Divya Deshmukh, and Tania Sachdev, also claimed a historic gold. While the men dominated early and secured the top spot with nearly a round to spare, the women faced a tightly contested battle before

Queen reigns supreme: Koneru Humpy capped off a landmark year for Indian chess by clinching the FIDE World Rapid Championship in New York. FIDE/MICHAŁ WALUSZA

clinching victory.

Individual brilliance shone through, with Divya and Vantika earning gold medals on their respective boards. The youth of India's contingent made the triumph even more remarkable — six out of the 10 players were under 23, and the average age of the four individual gold medalists was below 20.

The 18 connection

Leon Mendonca, Pranav Venkatesh, Gukesh, and Divya all had a unique way of celebrating their 18th year, leaving an indelible mark on the chess world in 2024.

Gukesh's celebratory tweet after becoming the 18th World Chess Champion — "18th @ 18" — perfectly encapsulated the idea that age is just